agreement under pressure is not consent. At the same time, nearly three-fourths expressed support for making consent education mandatory. This combination highlights both the need and the willingness to deepen understanding through education and dialogue.

These insights suggest that India is well positioned to build on the progress already underway. Awareness initiatives have laid an important foundation. The next opportunity is to establish a shared framework that reinforces these principles consistently across homes, schools, workplaces and public spaces.

This is why the country should consider adopting a Consent Charter.

At its heart, such a charter would reinforce a simple but powerful principle: every individual has the right to make decisions about their body, personal space, time and boundaries.

The principles are straightforward. Consent must be freely given. A 'yes' influenced by pressure, fear, guilt or emotional manipulation cannot be considered genuine consent.

Silence should never be interpreted as consent. Every individual has the right to say 'no' without feeling the need to apologise, explain or justify that decision. Simply put, 'no' is a complete sentence.

Consent is also ongoing. Agreeing once does not imply agreement forever. Every person has the right to change their mind at any stage, and that choice deserves respect.

Equally important, a refusal should always be met with understanding rather than pressure, ridicule or anger. Respecting another person's boundaries is one of the clearest expressions of mutual respect.

The idea of consent also extends well beyond intimate relationships. It applies equally to everyday situations, asking before hugging someone, seeking permission before sharing photographs, respecting children's boundaries, borrowing personal belongings, entering another person's personal space or accessing private information. In many ways, consent is simply about respecting another person's choices in every aspect of daily life.

The survey also found that most women view responsibility as shared. More than one in two respondents believe that everyone involved in an interaction shares equal responsibility for ensuring consent and maintaining respectful boundaries. This shared responsibility should be central to any national framework.

Families have a particularly important role to play. Many of the values that shape respectful relationships are learned early in life. When children are encouraged to ask permission, respect another person's 'no' and express their own preferences with confidence, these behaviours become lifelong habits.

A national Consent Charter need not be lengthy or complex. Its essence could be captured in a few simple principles. Consent must be informed, voluntary and ongoing. Every 'no' deserves respect. Respectful relationships begin by asking, not assuming.

India has demonstrated time and again that lasting social change is possible when governments, educators, businesses, communities and citizens work together. Public awareness around sanitation, hygiene and road safety has steadily become part of everyday behaviours through sustained and collective effort.

Consent presents a similar opportunity. The growing willingness to engage in these conversations, reflected throughout this survey, provides a strong foundation for the future. A Consent Charter would not be about creating new obligations. It would be about reinforcing a shared understanding of respect, choice and dignity, and helping these values become part of everyday life.

By building on the momentum that already exists, India has an opportunity to foster a culture where asking, listening and respecting boundaries become second nature. A Consent Charter could be an important next step in that shared national journey. ■





REACHING YOUNG MINDS Durex The Birds and Bees Talk's murals at a school; (left) its graffiti at the Hornbill Festival, Nagaland

A 'YES' INFLUENCED BY PRESSURE, FEAR, GUILT OR EMOTIONAL MANIPULATION CANNOT BE CONSIDERED GENUINE CONSENT

The author is Communications and Corporate Affairs Director, South Asia, MENARP and Africa, Reckitt. The views expressed in this article are his own and do not necessarily reflect the views of the company or its affiliates